

Though there are a few more open source audio compression technologies out there, the ones mentioned above are the most popular. It's time now to look at some software audio players.

2.2 Players

Though a lot of us are quite happy with players such as Winamp or Windows Media Player, some of us prefer the flexibility that accompanies the use of open source players. If you know your coding, you could actually customise and improve some of the players we will list below.

2.2.1 MPlayer

www.mplayerhq.hu

From the site: "MPlayer is a movie player which runs on many systems. It plays most MPEG/VOB, AVI, Ogg/OGM, VIVO, ASF/WMA/WMV, QT/MOV/MP4, RealMedia, Matroska, NUT, NupelVideo, FLI, YUV4MPEG, FILM, RoQ, PVA files, supported by many native, XAnim, and Win32 DLL codecs. You can watch VideoCD, SVCD, DVD, 3ivx, DivX 3/4/5 and even WMV movies."

That pretty much says it all as far as MPlayer's capabilities go. Now let's look at the actual experience. You can download a beta GUI version from the site, unless you just want to be the ultimate geek and use the command line version!

We're going to talk about the "experimental Windows GUI build" here, because, honestly, if we expect you to stop using players such as Winamp and WMP, which are known for their ease of use, and try out MPlayer, we'd rather you didn't struggle at a command prompt!

You can get various skins from the MPlayer site, and also from <http://themes.freshmeat.net/search/?q=mplayer§ion=projects>.

Overall, MPlayer is a decent open source media player, with all the basic functionality that's expected of it. You can read more about its video capabilities in the chapter that's coming up next.